SUNY Old Westbury 2026-2027 Undergraduate Catalog

Course Descriptions

Contract All Courses |

Criminology

CR 1500 - Introduction to Criminology

Credits: 4

This course will provide students with an introduction to the social scientific study of crime. Students will explore quantitative and qualitative evidence concerning various types of crime (e.g. murder, robbery, rape, domestic violence, child abuse, burglary, larceny, motor vehicle theft, organized crime, international crime, and white collar crime). Also, they will explore crime statistics concerning the demographic dimensions of crime (i.e. age, race, sex, and class). Students will be provided with a brief introduction to biological, psychological, and sociological explanations of crime, and learn to compare social science and media representations of crime and criminals. Finally, students will learn to assess conservative, liberal and radical explanations of historical crime trends, and to examine the impact of the criminal justice system (i.e. police, courts, corrections) on rates of crime.

When Offered:

Every semester.

CR 2090 - Juvenile Delinquency

Credits: 4

This course will provide an introduction to theories and research findings concerning causes of juvenile delinquency in U.S. society. In addition, social policies designed to address delinquency as a social problem will be explored.

Prerequisites

ECI

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

CR 3092 - Victimology

Credits: 4

This course will provide an introduction to theory and research about individuals and specific populations that have been victimized by interpersonal, institutional and state-sanctioned violence and abuse. Specific topics may include domestic violence and incest, rape, biased-related crimes, and post-trauma syndrome as a result of war, torture, social or environmental catastrophes. Students will also become acquainted with the variety of social services, specialized programs within the criminal justice system and practitioners who treat “survivors” of violence and abuse.

Prerequisites

EC ll

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

CR 3093 - Criminal Justice Administration

Credits: 4

This course introduces the student to conceptual frameworks, theories, and empirical research related to criminal justice administration. Students learn to understand criminal justice as a system, embedded within other systems, and to consider the interaction between (and the interdependence of) the major system components (police, prosecution, courts, and corrections). Issues of class, race and gender inequalities in the administration of justice are raised within historical contexts, and struggles for equal treatment under the law by victims, defendants, and historically marginalized minority communities are examined. Students apply what they have learned to a series of realistic case studies, and debate the effectiveness, constitutionality and ethics of the procedures used by police, lawyers, prisons, and re-entry programs. Questions about the potential need to reform criminal justice institutions are also discussed.

Prerequisites

EC ll

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

CR 3094 - Drugs and Society

Credits: 4

This course examines the use of drugs not only in contemporary American society, but also globally, and satisfies the Sociology Department's cross-cultural component. The course is arranged so that the material progresses from substances utilized in their natural forms, up to technological "designer" drugs. The problems and virtues of objectively and subjectively studying drug effects are addressed. The history and use of specific substances (i.e., caffeine, marijuana, cocaine) is extensively explored. Students are taught to think critically about drug information presented by the government, media, and pharmaceutical industries. The course investigates how drug use varies by class, race, and sex, and integrates this knowledge to critically assess current drug laws and policies.

Prerequisites

ECII

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

CR 3099 - Sociology of Violence

Credits: 4

This course provides a sociological inquiry into the various manifestations of violence in societies, including interpersonal forms of violence such as homicide, rape, and physical assault as well as collective forms of violence such as state-sponsored violence, war, genocide, terrorism and torture. Students will apply sociological and criminological theories in analyses of patterns of violence and specific violent events. The sociological causes and effects of individual and collective violent actions, including risk factors which increase the likelihood of violence across societies, will be discussed.

Prerequisites

CR 1500

; EMS ECII

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

CR 3117 - Policing Bodies

Credits: 4

This course examines the formal and informal ways in which sexual practices and identities are policed and produced. Central to this agenda will be a consideration of the ways in which sex and sexuality intersect with gender, race, ethnicity, and class in the construction and maintenance of systems of social control. Drawing on historical and contemporary contexts, the course will explore both the causes and the consequences of this bodily policing. Course topics will include: changing definitions of acceptable/unacceptable sex and sexual identity; evolving methods of surveillance and regulation of sexual behaviors and identities; and the relationships between social institutions, social interaction, and individual experience.

Prerequisites

ECII

CR 3200 - Crime, Media and Culture

Credits: 4

This course explores the ways that media and cultural processes socially construct crime in modern society. Drawing on the latest theories of culture and crime, students will investigate the relationships among mass media, individual agency, actual crime and criminal justice. Emphasis will be on crime news, popular representations of crime, contemporary media portrayals of different types of crime and their interactions with racial, ethnic, class and gender stereotypes.

Prerequisites

ECII

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

CR 4000 - Gender, Crime and Justice

Credits: 4

This course will examine the role of gender in the criminal legal system. It will cover the relative status of women and men from the late 19th century to the present, and the process of becoming full and equal participants in society. The course will use major sociological theories of gender difference to understand offenders and defendants; prisoners; law enforcement professionals; and victims of this system. Current programs for community based justice and the tension between theories of gender difference, practices and programs for women in the legal system, and conservative and feminist political views regarding the abilities and disabilities of women will also be included.

Prerequisites

CR 1500

; EMS

CR 4091 - Punishment and Corrections

Credits: 4

Students are introduced to the sociology of punishment and corrections. The historical development and form of modern corrections systems in the United States are explored. Various punishment and correction strategies, ideologies, and policy alternatives are assessed.

Prerequisites

CR 1500

; EMS

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

CR 4550 - Theories of Crime

Credits: 4

Students will read a variety of theoretical writings, and ethnographies, from the literature on crime and deviance. Classes and assignments will be designed to enable students to summarize, assess, and critique these theories in light of the intersection of numerous sociological variables such as race, sex, and social class. In addition to addressing subjects such as the making of laws, the breaking of laws, and the reaction to the breaking of laws, the implications of theoretical criminology for social/criminal justice policy will be explored.

Prerequisites

CR 1500

, EMS

When Offered:

Every year.

CR 4999 - Issues in Criminology

Credits: 4

Gives students the opportunity to examine in greater depth the analysis and discussion of current specialized criminological work in the particular area defined by the instructor (as indicated in the schedule of classes). Students are permitted to take CR 4999 Issues in Criminology for credit and as fulfillment of elective requirements for the Criminology and Sociology Majors up to two times in which two distinct topics are covered.

Prerequisites

CR 1500

; EMS

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

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